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Travel Radio Australia, and we're here at the Arrival 360 Brisbane travel event, and I have Mack Gorn from the great company Tashi, that's T-A-S-H-I. Mack, welcome to the program. Hi, great to meet you, Geoff.

Now, tell us a bit about yourself first. Now you're Irish, living in Australia, and how did you get here, basically? As many people say, I have a long story, but yeah, Irish originally came here 14, 15 years ago, after a short three-year detour in Nepal, where I was living and working, running an anti-child trafficking charity, as it was at the time, and that's how I got first into travel too, because I set up a not-for-profit trekking company called Umbrella Trekking, and got really passionate about sustainable tourism, and kind of giving, you know, modern tools to local companies, so they can make a bigger impact. Tashi, you're with Tashi now, which is T-H-S-H-I.

Tell us about that company. Yeah, so Tashi.travel, we help travel businesses build and run their niche OTAs, or travel marketplaces. So instead of just selling their own tours, they can bring in operators, manage inventory, inquiries, bookings, customers, suppliers, and distribution from our central platform.

We're basically like the infrastructure layer, or an operating system for niche travel OTAs and marketplaces, and so the people we tend to work with are those who've already kind of grown, maybe they've outgrown like a basic booking engine, or generic platform, or you know, they're trying to build something like their own Viator for their niche, that geographical or segment around the world. And so we're Australian founded and headquartered, but we work with a lot of people all across the world, as you'd expect, not just here in Down Under, but you know, MENA region, or then basically the Gulf region, and North America as well, especially. Now you get to travel yourself, I'm sure with Tashi, and tell us about some of the places you've been in the past couple of years.

Very, very lucky to see some amazing places, especially with the work that Tashi did. In our earlier years, actually back in 2019, I spent a bit of time in Amsterdam, where you'd said you spend a lot of your time too, with the booking.com team there. And then we actually had a lot of our early growth in Southern Africa, a lot of the safari operators in South Africa, Botswana, Namibia had an amazing four-week self-driving tour around Namibia back in 2019 with my partner, which was really just one of those transformational travel, as the buzzwords go.

The story of booking.com is incredible, because that was just a little company in Amsterdam, and I know the headquarters very well in the Rembrandtsplein there. It's just become huge, hasn't it? It went from really a backyard operation to something really big. It has over a very long period of time, of course, and the quality of the people that work there are phenomenal.

And so they were one of the early believers in what Tashi does, in that we, again, would have

started out solely focused on more sustainable operators only, and we got support from them through their booking cares program, which was financial, and then also like mentorship program back in 2019. And we get to know people who work there. And it's one of those places where maybe when you're outside looking in, you think it's kind of this big faceless corporate, and somewhat maybe ignorantly, you think it's kind of footy-dooty.

But once you're in there and you see the quality of the people that operate there, and at the time, they would have just purchased Fair Harbor, who would be recognized as one of the biggest travel tech companies for the tour activity sector. And so it was really, really interesting and insightful for us as kind of a new startup in the space to kind of learn from them at the time. Tell us about... You touched on the African things you did before, you know, and the safaris.

But there must have been some other travel experiences that you've done in your life. Can you give us about two or three of the really amazing things that you've managed to experience? For sure. Well, I mean, starting with Nepal, where, as I said, I lived for a couple of years.

And when you do your first kind of Himalayan trek, and you hike in 10 or 12 days into the Annapurna Circuit, as it was for me at the time, about 15 years ago, you're kind of cut off. Five days walking to get in there and five days to get out. Close-knit group of friends or people you've just met, actually, and they become friends.

And that was really beautiful kind of stuff, because I think in Nepal, like many places, technology is starting to eke into every nook and cranny of the country. But at the time, it was definitely off the beaten track, the circuit I did, where there's no phones, no internet, and it's just you and a couple of books that you've kind of brought your way. And so that was one great one.

And not so long after that, I was lucky to go to Myanmar back in 2013 with my partner as well. I just have a really vivid memory of going to one of the big pagodas in the center of the city in Yangon. Kind of sight unseen almost, just jumping in a taxi and going there, as is the case in a lot of these cultural attractions.

There's lots of friendly locals willing to show you around for a little price. And we met this lovely guy who walked us around super slow pace, talked us through it all. And at the time, it just felt very special to be in his company in that space, which was, you know, such a stunning, stunning area.

And with my partners, we are, I will admit, we're in the early throes of our relationship. So that always means that it has a special place in my heart, that kind of particular trip. We can tell you by your accent, you grew up in Dublin.

And what's the difference between living in Australia now and Dublin? You really love it here, don't you? Well, can't you tell by my tan? I'm a proud Irishman, grew up playing Irish music, playing Irish sports, speaking Irish language with my family as well. So that's been something I

brought with me. I still play Irish music to this day in the local Irish pubs here in the Sunshine Coast.

Quality of life that me and my family have here is second to none, really. And we feel very grateful. We live on the Sunshine Coast, like I mentioned, just an hour and a half north of here in Brisbane.

And, you know, right on the ocean, you're able to go for a swim in the waves a couple of times a week. There's lots of greenery, lots of outdoors, which is kind of what I really love, you know. So again, I try and make it back to Dublin when I can and to see my family, of course, and bring the family with me as well.

I'll always be Irish, you know, and that's something that I'm always proud of. But at the same time, Australia is one of those countries that, because it's, you know, it's a very welcoming place and you can kind of maybe get a lot of great opportunities here. So that's why, yeah, I'm very, very happy where I am.

Well, I grew up in Dublin too. So just every summer of my childhood, so I can say Cade Meal of Fortress, Slainter and Deas Marigot to you too in the Gaelic language. That's it, Deas Marigot.

Marigot, that's it, which is God bless you in the Irish language. Tell us a bit more about Tashi. How can people find you online to check things out, whether they be a tour operator? You're more of a B2B business rather than a business to consumer, but everyone can visit and have a look, right? Absolutely, yeah.

Tashi.travel. So T-A-S-H-I.travel and jump online there. And we're always looking to connect to really great companies and partners, not just people looking to launch that next, you know, niche via tour, but also even we work with a lot of tour operators themselves and partner with obviously a lot of like tech infrastructure there because we, you know, we do a lot of that kind of like born-behind-the-scenes infrastructure plumbing for this amazing industry. Well, lovely to have you on the program, Mack Gawne from Tashi.

It's been a pleasure. Yeah, thanks, Geoff. Lovely to meet you.